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by Rahul Sharma

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BMA6105

Managing Sustainability

Assignment 2: Personal Reflections

Topic: From Measuring My Carbon Footprint to Changing My Behaviour:
Rethinking Personal Responsibility for Climate Action

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1.0 Introduction

This reflective account assesses how measuring my carbon footprint became a turning point in recognising my own accountability for climate change. I do not see the calculation as a one-off measurement, but as a way to build awareness of the links between individual behaviours and the social system, which helps us sustain our environment in the long run. This represents a shift from what Kenneth Boulding described as the 'cowboy economy' to the 'spaceman economy', characterised by acknowledging limited resources (Haas et al., 2020). This reflection relies on significant ideas addressed in the module to assess how I changed my perceptions during the course, such as ecological footprint, responsible consumption, systems thinking, and behaviour change.

2.0 Measuring My Carbon Footprint

Learning about what my carbon footprint is opened my eyes to the reality of how important sustainability is. Before this module, I thought of myself as an environmentally aware person, with habits that included recycling and avoiding wasteful practices. The results of the carbon footprint exercise proved that I was mistaken because the major factors determining my environmental impact were not individual actions but the sum of my daily choices in regard to transport, food, energy at home, and consumption. This coincides with the idea of ecological footprint, describing the load on the planet caused by human activities (Rees and Wackernagel, 1996).

My primary focus does not hinge on the large footprint I made, but rather on how contrasting my environmental values are compared to what I do daily. I always assumed that having awareness and concern for climate matters equals responsible living, but the exercise revealed that I based my actions on convenience most of the time. For instance, I never thought of the environmental implications of buying new products while the old ones were still useful, or my choice of transport based on speed. Acknowledging these

behaviours was alarming since it contradicted my self-image of being a responsible customer (Mizrachi and Sharon, 2025).

I came to understand that I have been thinking about my sustainability mostly in terms of the behaviours of turning things green- recycling and avoiding litter- and missing many times the less visible forms of consumption having much more negative impact on the environment. The task brought out one major bias as I kept associating sustainability with separate "green" acts instead of relating to the whole lifestyle (Andrade and Vieites, 2025). The activity transformed how I approached the question of whether behaviour is environmentally friendly and made me ask whether it is actually essential. This prompted increased critical thinking with respect to the notions of convenience, consumerism, and the cumulative impact of repeated decisions in this context (La Ragione and Risitano, 2025).

Moreover, it enhanced my understanding of the principle of ecological footprint in that sustainability is defined not on the basis of separate actions, but through the relationship between human needs and Earth capacity (Rees and Wackernagel, 1996). I learned to recognise carbon footprint as a self-reflective tool that allows for continuous improvement of behaviour rather than attaining the maximum environmentally friendly score. While footprint calculators are great for visualising the environmental effects of one's actions, they oversimplify the complex issue of sustainability into a number (Wright et al., 2011). They fail to account for indirect emissions in global supply chain operations, varying infrastructure and different levels of social justice influencing sustainable choices made by people (Barros and Wilk, 2021).

I have thus changed my understanding of the concept of carbon footprint and now see it merely as a measurement reflecting the need for behavioural changes rather than a definitive measure of sustainability. Instead of asking,

"What is the level of my carbon footprint?" I began to question, "Why do I behave in this way regularly, particularly in light of my impact on the environment?" That shift from asking questions about levels to becoming aware of my actions ultimately lays the foundation for my new approach to the subject of my responsibility for taking climate action.

3.0 Rethinking Personal Responsibility

3.1 Individual responsibility within planetary limits

Before taking this module, my understanding of climate action only revolved around making better choices in daily life such as recycling, for example, more often or using less energy. Although these approaches continue to play a role, my understanding shifted when I came across Boulding's idea of Spaceship Earth (Haas et al., 2020). Boulding claims that humans no longer live in an 'open' system where there are no restrictions on resource use, but instead in a closed ecological system where nature's resources are limited and waste management becomes an important process of sustainability (Haas et al., 2020).

As a result, my view of individual consumption as being of no significance when compared to major greenhouse gas emissions changed. It made me realize that millions of consumption choices actually impact the demand for energy, transportation, food, and manufactured products. However, this module has also made it clear that personal responsibility is not synonymous with blaming the individual. The ecological footprint concept discusses the ecological demand that lifestyles' sustainability creates, yet there is a huge impact of the underlying infrastructure and economic structures people live under in creating that demand (Kitzes et al., 2007). For example, people choose to rely on public transport only if there is a reliable transport system available in the given area, and opting for sustainable products highly depends on affordability and the

availability of those products locally (Jelti et al., 2021). Although people have control over their decisions, the overall context thus provides the necessary circumstances for the decision-making.

3.2 A systems-thinking perspective on climate action

The most important transformation in my thoughts relates to adopting a systems perspective. According to the module, Doughnut Economics says that in order to be sustainable, societies need to address human requirements and adhere to ecological boundaries (Raworth, 2017). This made me understand that cutting back on carbon emissions alone does not contribute to sustainability if there are social inequalities and resource abuse in other parts of the supply chain. Equally, according to UNESCO's sustainability competencies, systems thinking and self-awareness are among the main skills needed to solve complicated sustainability problems (Annelin and Boström, 2022).

The discussion of the Rana Plaza incident in this module illustrated the relation between consumer demand on unsafe working conditions and failures related to the supply chain as a whole (Alam et al., 2025). In a similar manner, sustainable consumption is not limited to only purchasing green products but means reducing consumption intensity as such, prolonging product longevity, and improving resource efficiency to the maximum extent (Maldini et al., 2025). As a result, the concept of individual responsibility in my understanding has changed: I now understand that one does not have to achieve a perfect carbon footprint, but make intelligent choices and understand the system of interconnectedness between people, corporations, governments and nature (Mahajan et al., 2023). These systems views began defining my understanding of the possibility of climate action.

4.0 From Awareness to Behaviour Change

4.1 Redefining sustainable consumption in my everyday life

The most significant shift in my perception of learning has been about realising that sustainability is not merely a movement to buy "greener" goods but rather the pursuit of investigating consumption practices. Sustainable consumption is considered the use of limited ecological resources to cover the needs of mankind as well as hazardous materials. It also concerns avoiding waste over the entire life cycle while maintaining the quality of life for succeeding generations (Holden et al., 2014). Initially, I thought that the process of sustainable consumption meant just replacing a regular product with eco-friendly ones. What dawned on me is that even the latter approach assumes that people will keep consuming more (Braungart et al., 2007).

Previously, I would justify making purchases of clothing or electronic goods depending on how cheap they were or how they were marketed as better versions of goods I already owned. Upon reflection, I noted that I was giving in to the allure of convenience and novelty rather than actual need (Savy and Sarkar, 2026). As a result, I now try to postpone making non-essential purchases, asking myself if repairing or using something for a longer time is possible, and thinking more about durability than short-term affordability of the goods. The module presents reducing consumption patterns and increasing the lifespan of goods as useful strategies for improving one's environmental footprint, which is actually more realisable for me than striving for a green lifestyle (Bradley et al., 2025).

4.2 Understanding why behaviour is difficult to change

One of the most interesting concepts for me was the idea of the intention-behaviour gap, which addresses the fact that people tend not to be very environmentally friendly even though they know it is not right. The SHIFT model suggests that social pressure, habits, and visibility of environmental

consequences influence behavior (White et al., 2019). This concept is relevant to me because it clarifies the contradictions I have witnessed during the footprint exercise.

Before this module, climate change had largely been a topic I believed to be a global one expressed in numbers and predictions about the future. After calculating my footprint, however, it became a concrete concept with practical implications in my daily life rather than an abstract idea. Consequently, my motivation shifted from the general understanding of the importance of sustainability towards making small daily changes in life instead of being overwhelmed by the sensational idea of changing the lifestyle entirely (Linder et al., 2021).

The most challenging aspect in my case has been the habit. I noticed that most environmental choices I took did not signify conscious decisions but merely practices that did not require many considerations. According to the SHIFT model, environment-friendly behaviour comes about when new habits step in to replace the old ones rather than relying on motivation alone (de Costa et al., 2025). Therefore, I stopped concentrating on being "more motivated" but rather attempted to replace my previous practices with new ones, for instance, planning trips ahead of time, using reusable objects regularly, and preparing food for busy days beforehand.

Social influence was another factor that was noticeable in my behaviour. I used to underestimate the impact of the ideas of convenience, normality, and consumerism on my purchasing habits. Understanding this made me less critical about myself and other people since neither is guilty of living in an unsustainable way as everyone is influenced by more complex systems rather than individual assumptions.

5.0 Personal Action Plan and Future Commitment

The most important lesson I have learned from this module is that sustainability is a goal to achieve through a continuous process of examining and improving everyday decisions, resulting in a combined lifestyle impact on a lowered carbon footprint. Measuring my own footprint made me more aware of the issues, but the real challenge lies in maintaining my behaviour despite the convenience and cost of less sustainable options. My future approach is based on the principle of continuous improvement instead of aiming for perfection in the field of environmental management, reflected in the Plan–Do–Check–Act, or PDCA cycle. According to it, a sustainable approach goes through planning, action implementation, monitoring of the results, and revision of the current solutions along the way (Silva et al., 2017).

It is my intention to limit excess consumption as an individual consumer by developing values of repair when it comes to clothing and electronic goods. The commitment I am making takes into account the understanding that reducing pollution involves less consumerism rather than seeking for alternatives labelled as green products. As a responsible citizen, I will continue to use efficient ways of travelling and eating that cause less pollution such as walking or using public transport where possible and making plans for meals in order to avoid food waste (Thomas and Serrenho, 2024). My behaviour is relevant to my daily routine and may become habitual.

The crucial lesson that I have learnt from this module is that practices of reflection are almost as important for sustainability as developing environmentally friendly behaviours. It is not reasonable to expect every decision made in the future to lead to the reduction of carbon emissions, especially when cost, availability and time aspects affect everyday decision making. Acknowledging limitations allows me to overcome an idealistic view of sustainability and understand it from a standpoint of resilience. Meaningful

progress can be achieved via continuous enhancement rather than occasional perfection (Scordato and Gulbrandsen, 2024).

In order to substantiate my claim, I will conduct a continuous personal review of my consumption behaviour similar to how organisations monitor their environmental performance through continuous improvement systems. As demonstrated by the PDCA cycle, an effective strategy for promoting sustainability consists of objective definition, change implementation, outcome evaluation, and improvement of further actions (Silva et al., 2017). In my case, implementation of this principle will involve being conscious of my transport as well as food and purchase choices throughout the year rather than considering climate actions as a single event.

As I look towards my future career, I see that my commitments go beyond lifestyle choices. Systems thinking, strategic thinking and self-awareness serve as key competencies for sustainability leaders (Annelin and Boström, 2022).

Regardless of which industry I work in, I aspire to contribute towards establishing a corporate culture of sustainable practices that can ensure responsible decision making and effective resource management, and a simultaneous equilibrium between environmental, economic and social aspects (Elkington, 1997). This represents a significant shift in thinking of mine, as I stopped viewing climate action as just something I do in the decisions I make at home.

6.0 Conclusion

This module allowed me to shift my notions of personal responsibility in tackling climate change. At first, I thought that being sustainable simply meant that I need to make better individual decisions. However, measuring my carbon footprint helped me understand that what matters not the outcome of the assessment, but the opportunity to rethink our behavior and consumption

patterns, which ultimately generate our footprint. Consequently, the carbon footprint has become a tool for making decisions rather than an indicator of achieving sustainability.

In addition, the concepts relating to sustainable consumption helped to alter my opinion that climate action is about acting independently. Instead of perceiving people and businesses as distinct units, I have come to understand that they are jointly liable for preparing enabling conditions for sustainable behaviour to develop. This systems-based viewpoint has convinced me to expand my thinking beyond emissions reduction by taking into account how my actions can impact long-term environmental sustainability.

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